

project.org

LIBRARY LESSON PLAN

Harlem Renaissance Library Session

Grades 3–5 · 40 minutes · Research skills + close reading

THE 40 MINUTES

5 min	7 min	5 min	18 min	5 min
HOOK	READING	ART LOOK	ACTIVITY CARDS	SHARE

SESSION GOALS

What students will do

Students will: use the exhibition and library resources to practice research skills; connect primary sources (poems, art, music) to historical context; develop descriptive and analytical writing; and understand how the library is a portal to the past — the stories here are the same ones the Harlem Renaissance artists were creating.

PREPARATION

- **Pull and display:** 8–10 relevant library books (see recommendations, page 2)
- **Tables set:** differentiated activity cards, pencils; optionally set up 2–3 research stations with books open to relevant sections
- **Project:** Great Migration Map and one Douglas image for whole-group opening

SESSION FLOW

0–5 MIN Opening hook	Show the Great Migration Map. *"In 1915, a Black family in Georgia could be arrested for almost nothing, couldn't vote, and would never own the land they farmed. A letter arrives from Chicago: 'Come north. There are factory jobs. The schools are better.' Over the next 50 years, 6 million people made that decision. The whole of Harlem changed because of it. Today we're going to look at what they created when they got there."*
5–12 MIN Whole-group reading	Read aloud one Langston Hughes poem (teacher choice — "I, Too" works well; "Mother to Son" also excellent). Ask: What do you notice about the language? Who is speaking? What is the argument? How is this poem like a letter, a protest, and a prayer all at once?
12–17 MIN Art and source look	Show Douglas, *Song of the Towers*. Quick pair-share: two observations + one question. Introduce the idea that the painting and the poem were made at the same time, in the same neighborhood — Douglas and Hughes knew each other.
17–35 MIN Activity cards	Students work on differentiated cards. Encourage library book use for the Red-level research task. Circulate and ask probing questions: *"How do you know? Where's your evidence? What else does this make you wonder?"*
35–40 MIN Share and close	One student each from Yellow and Red shares their most interesting finding. *"The books on these shelves are a direct line to the people we studied today. The library is where their voices are still alive."*

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Option 1 — Visit the Exhibition: Bring your class to experience the phonograph, the Great Migration Map, the Jazz Lab, and more. Ask your librarian to arrange a visit.

Option 2 — Virtual Visit:

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance

BOOK RECOMMENDATIONS · GRADES 3–5

BIOGRAPHY AND HISTORY

Langston Hughes: A Biography — Milton Meltzer — comprehensive, accessible

Voice of Freedom: Fannie Lou Hamer — Carole Boston Weatherford — award-winning format

Zora Hurston and the Chinaberry Tree — William Miller — picture-book biography

Duke Ellington: The Piano Prince — Andrea Davis Pinkney — excellent at this level

Stompin' at the Savoy — Karen Deans — Lindy Hop at the Savoy Ballroom

PRIMARY TEXT ACCESS

Poetry for Young People: Langston Hughes — selected with classroom notes

The Dream Keeper and Other Poems — Langston Hughes — designed for young readers

Soul Looks Back in Wonder — Tom Feelings — anthology with Harlem Renaissance figures

Harlem Renaissance: A Brief History with Documents — higher level, for Red extension

Online — Poetry Foundation (poets.org) has all Hughes poems freely accessible

RESEARCH SKILLS INTEGRATION

This session is an ideal opportunity to integrate research skills instruction:

- **Finding a book:** Model using the catalog to find Harlem Renaissance books by subject heading
- **Using an index:** Show students how to use the index in a biography to find specific information quickly
- **Evaluating sources:** Ask: what's the difference between reading a poem Langston Hughes wrote vs. reading a book about Langston Hughes? Which is a primary source?
- **Note-taking:** Red-level students should practice paraphrasing — not copying — from sources they find